WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

Connecting International Capital

SOUTH SUDAN

Africa

Information current as of October 2026

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office@lordwaverley.com
www.lordwaverley.com

WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

Location / Region	Strategic Importance	Priority Sectors
Juba	Capital and main commercial centre; seat of government, the Bank of South Sudan, the Ministry of Petroleum and the development-partner community	Trade and distribution, construction, banking, services
Unity State oilfields (Blocks 1, 2 and 4)	GPOC-operated fields that reached 60,158 barrels per day in May 2026, the highest since 2005, and drove national output to around 170,000–174,000 barrels per day	Upstream oil, oilfield services, field redevelopment
Tharjiath (Unity State)	Planned site of an initial 30,000 barrel-per-day refinery, the first stage of 60,000 barrels per day of new refining capacity	Refining, fuel storage and distribution
Upper Nile oil region	Established producing area and a named potential refinery location at Thiangrial	Upstream oil, refining, midstream logistics
Open exploration acreage (14 blocks)	Proven reserves of around 3.5 billion barrels, nearly 90% untapped, with five blocks offered in the first licensing round	Exploration, geoscience, upstream services
Nimule–Juba corridor	Backbone of trade with Uganda and onward to the East African ports of Mombasa and Dar es Salaam	Road logistics, trucking, warehousing, cross-border trade
Equatoria agricultural belt	Fertile southern region where harvested land rose 6.2% and crop yields 8.3% in 2024, supporting import substitution	Agriculture, agro-processing, food supply

INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- Investment Promotion Act 2009, which established the national Investment Authority, issues investment certificates carrying tax incentives, and guarantees against expropriation without fair compensation
- Statutory right to transfer investment capital, loan servicing and sale proceeds in and out of the country, with investor–state disputes open to international arbitration, including ICSID, at the investor's option
- Ministry of Petroleum licensing: 14 open exploration blocks, five of them offered in the country's first licensing round, plus refinery, storage and distribution projects being advanced through MoUs
- Currency regime: the South Sudanese pound trades at official and parallel rates, and unifying them is a core goal of the IMF Staff-Monitored Program agreed in 2025; investors should confirm dollar availability and repatriation mechanics with their banks
- East African Community membership (since 2016), giving access to regional trade arrangements and the Mombasa and Dar es Salaam port corridors

- Co-investment alongside the World Bank, AfDB and IMF-supported reform programmes, which anchor fiscal transparency, oil-sector governance and payment of salary arrears
- Sanctions-compliant structuring: all counterparties and payment routes screened against UN, US and UK South Sudan and Sudan sanctions lists before commitment

MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

South Sudan in October 2026 is in an oil-led recovery. After the 2024 rupture of the export pipeline through Sudan cut production from about 160,000 to around 60,000 barrels per day, flows resumed in April 2025 and national output has since climbed to around 170,000–174,000 barrels per day, with the Ministry of Petroleum targeting 230,000 barrels per day in the short term and 450,000 over the longer term. The World Bank projects a 48.8% rebound in 2026 after a 23.8% contraction in FY2025, while the IMF's current projection is a more measured 4.1%, with inflation forecast to ease to 14% from around 143% in FY2024/25. Public debt is about 58% of GDP. A nine-month IMF Staff-Monitored Program agreed in 2025 targets exchange-rate unification, tight monetary policy and oil-sector transparency, and the country's first oil licensing round, five of 14 open blocks, and plans for 60,000 barrels per day of new refining capacity mark a clear opening of the energy sector to new investors.

The main structural challenge is security, at home and along the export route. Domestically, fighting between government forces and the SPLA-IO since 2025 has left the 2018 peace agreement largely unimplemented; opposition leader Riek Machar remains under house arrest facing treason charges, clashes have been concentrated in Jonglei and Upper Nile, and the UN Security Council renewed its arms embargo, asset freeze and travel ban on 29 May 2026 until 31 May 2027. Elections are scheduled for December 2026, though preparations remain behind schedule. Externally, all crude exports run through Sudan, where the RSF has controlled the Heglig area since December 2025 and now collects part of the transit fee. Mitigation lies in careful site selection, professional security and sanctions advice, and partnership with established operators and development-finance institutions. The opportunity is substantial: a resource base nearly 90% untapped, a government actively seeking upstream, refining and power partners, and investors positioned now will be best placed as security and governance improve.

INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
UN arms embargo and targeted sanctions	Resolution 2821 (29 May 2026) renewed the UN arms embargo, asset freeze and travel ban until 31 May 2027, with a Panel of Experts to 1 July 2027 and benchmarks reviewed by 15 April 2027	Retain sanctions counsel, screen all counterparties and avoid any security-sector supply; civilian commercial sectors remain lawfully open
US and UK national sanctions	The US maintains a South Sudan sanctions programme with officials designated as recently as 2023, and the UK operates its own regime covering conduct including misappropriation of state funds	Screen against OFAC and UK lists, apply enhanced due diligence on politically exposed partners and document beneficial ownership
Domestic conflict and peace-process delays	Fighting between government and SPLA-IO forces, mainly in Jonglei and Upper Nile, has stalled the 2018 peace agreement, and elections set for December 2026 remain uncertain	Base operations in Juba and established oil areas, use professional security assessments and plan for election-period volatility; progress on the benchmarks would widen the investable map
Export route through Sudan	All crude reaches the Red Sea via pipelines through Sudan; the RSF has held the Heglig area since December 2025 and receives $4 of the $11 per barrel transit fee, and several RSF commanders are under US sanctions	Oil investors should take specialist sanctions advice on transit-fee flows and model short pipeline outages; refining and regional corridors reduce route concentration
Oil dependence	Oil provides around 90% of government revenue and the bulk of exports, so output and prices drive the whole economy	Rising output and new licensing create upstream openings, while agriculture, logistics and power offer diversification plays
Currency and inflation	The pound trades at official and parallel rates (a 30.8% premium in June 2025),	Hold revenues in dollars where possible, hedge local-currency costs and track IMF-

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
	although inflation is projected to ease to around 14% in 2026	backed exchange-rate unification
Infrastructure and humanitarian needs	Limited roads, power and data, and 7.8 million people facing acute food insecurity, raise operating costs	Partner with DFIs and humanitarian supply chains; power, logistics and food production face strong unmet demand

INVESTOR RISK NOTE

South Sudan offers frontier exposure to one of Africa's least-explored oil provinces, with output back above 170,000 barrels per day, a first licensing round under way and growth forecast to rebound strongly in 2026. Investors must, however, factor in legal realities plainly: the UN arms embargo, asset freeze and travel ban were renewed on 29 May 2026 until 31 May 2027; the US and UK operate their own South Sudan sanctions regimes; and the crude export route crosses RSF-held territory in Sudan, where transit-fee payments raise distinct sanctions questions. Domestically, the 2018 peace agreement has stalled amid renewed fighting, and December 2026 elections remain uncertain. None of these measures bars civilian commercial investment, but each requires sanctions counsel, rigorous counterparty screening, professional security planning and close engagement with development-finance partners. Investors who build that compliance and security discipline in from the outset can participate lawfully today and will be well positioned for the gains that would follow progress on the UN benchmarks and a credible political transition.

MARKET ACCESS

South Sudan joined the East African Community in 2016, linking it to the regional market and to the ports of Mombasa and Dar es Salaam, with the Nimule–Juba axis forming the backbone of trade with Uganda and Kenya and Sudan also among its main sources of consumer goods. The country is pursuing WTO accession and has endorsed a national AfCFTA implementation strategy with the UN Economic Commission for Africa. Crude oil, which accounts for the large majority of exports, travels via two pipeline systems through Sudan to Port Sudan on the Red Sea, carrying a combined 160,000 barrels per day or more in 2025. Planned domestic refining capacity and deeper East African integration offer complementary routes to market as the economy diversifies beyond oil.

WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Office of the President (Salva Kiir Mayardit)	Centre of executive authority over the economy, the oil sector and the peace and electoral process	Primary reference point for strategic direction, peace-agreement implementation and the December 2026 elections
Investment Authority (Investment Promotion Act 2009)	Statutory body issuing investment certificates and administering incentives and investor guarantees	First point of contact for registration, incentives and investment-certificate terms
Ministry of Petroleum	Leads the licensing round, production targets and refinery and midstream partnerships	Essential counterpart for any upstream, refining or energy-services engagement
Bank of South Sudan (Governor James Alic Garang)	Monetary authority responsible for inflation, the pound and the official exchange rate	Relevant for currency, banking and repatriation matters
Ministry of Finance and Planning	Manages oil revenue, the budget, arrears and the IMF Staff-Monitored Program	Key counterpart on fiscal reforms, public payments and government contracts
Greater Pioneer Operating Company (GPOC)	Operator of Blocks 1, 2 and 4 in Unity State and the main driver of 2026 output growth	Practical partner for oilfield services and field redevelopment
UN Security Council South Sudan Sanctions Committee and Panel of Experts	Administers the arms embargo and designations, renewed until May 2027, and reviews progress against benchmarks	Reference point for compliance screening and for tracking any future easing of measures

CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

South Sudan Oil & Power 2026, the seventh edition, held in Juba on 24–25 November in official partnership with the Ministry of Petroleum, is the principal investor forum and the main platform for the licensing round, refinery projects and power opportunities. The IMF resident representative office, the World Bank and the African Development Bank are active in Juba and provide authoritative economic and reform intelligence, while operators in the GPOC-led Unity State fields are a practical source of insight into on-the-ground logistics. Regional business links run through the East African Community and the Kenyan and Ugandan trading networks along the Nimule–Juba corridor, and UNMISS and humanitarian agencies are valuable sources of security and access information.

INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

South Sudan best suits experienced frontier and specialist investors with strong compliance and security capability: independent oil companies and oilfield-service firms targeting the licensing round and field redevelopment; refining, storage and fuel-distribution investors responding to planned new capacity; logistics and trading firms operating on the Nimule–Juba corridor; and agriculture, power and telecoms investors co-investing alongside development-finance institutions. All investors should operate with sanctions counsel and a clear framework for engagement within lawfully permitted civilian sectors.

FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Commission sanctions and legal due diligence first
Engage counsel to map UN, US and UK South Sudan and Sudan sanctions exposure, screen partners and payment routes, and confirm the investment sits within lawfully permitted civilian activity.

STEP 2: Engage the Ministry of Petroleum and the Investment Authority
Assess licensing-round blocks, refinery and midstream opportunities, and the incentives and guarantees available through investment certificates under the 2009 Act.

STEP 3: Build security and export-route scenarios into planning
Commission professional security assessments and model short pipeline outages and election-period volatility, drawing on UNMISS and operator intelligence.

STEP 4: Partner with development-finance institutions
Explore co-investment with the World Bank and AfDB, whose programmes and the IMF-supported reforms add structure, transparency and risk-sharing.

STEP 5: Attend South Sudan Oil & Power in November 2026
Use the Juba forum to meet ministry officials, operators and service companies and to test project terms before committing capital.